Aside from diplomatic protest, the prospect of Chinese economic coercion remains a threat to India, one that Japan can do little to alleviate. In a future crisis, if China were to punish India by withholding exports, it is unlikely that India could rely on Japanese exports as a substitute, given the latter's very different composition and the high transaction costs involved in such a shift for both India and Japan. Moreover, China's manipulated exchange rate and low labour costs ensure the competitiveness of its exports, and any country switching to a different and more expensive trading partner is likely to face domestic political backlash from consumers accustomed to Chinese-made goods. Even in the midst of the Doklam crisis of mid-2017, as imports from China soared compared to the previous year, an Indian economist observed that "The political tension ... is unlikely to have any impact on the trade relations between the two countries."[42] Thus, although analysts have argued that India pursues a hedging strategy (i.e. using one bilateral relationship to offset the risks of another bilateral relationship) toward China by building an economic partnership with Japan,[43] a hedge on Sino–Indian trade with Japan is unlikely to play out to India's advantage. Hedging is more likely to work in the case of investment, a domain in which Chinese companies have made significant inroads into India over the last two years.[44] India's investment-focused relationship with Japan thus acts as useful long-term insurance in the event that relations with China descend into economic warfare.

In the final analysis, India–China relations are sufficiently complex for India to think twice about unreservedly supporting Japan in any potential dispute. No doubt Japan's longer-term goal is to precisely become the more attractive economic partner. Yet this goal will remain elusive until China's relative trade advantage is eroded somehow. This also explains why India–Japan trade is only a small